

Recognize it

Green bass with dark lateral band; closed jaw extends beyond rear of eye.

Body	Deep-bodied; first and second dorsal sections separated by a deep notch.
Mouth/fins	Very large mouth; tongue lacks a tooth patch.
Confusion	Smallmouth jaw ends near mid-eye and usually shows vertical bars.

Lake role

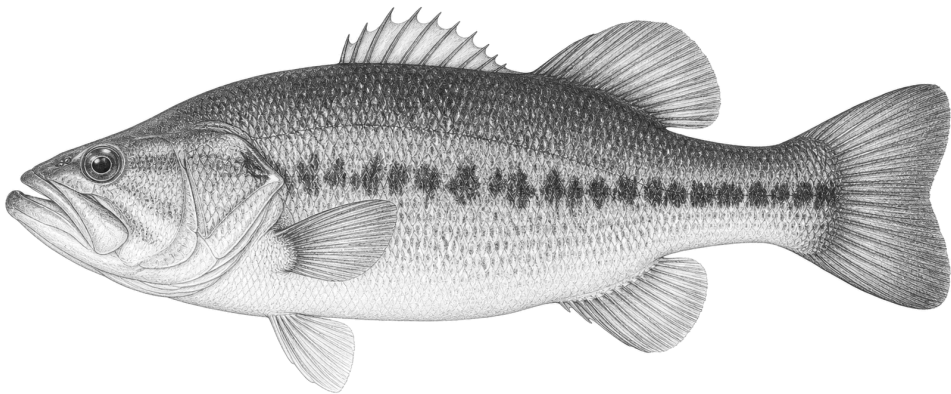
Where it belongs

Vegetation, wood, docks, shade, and nearby depth.

Food and season

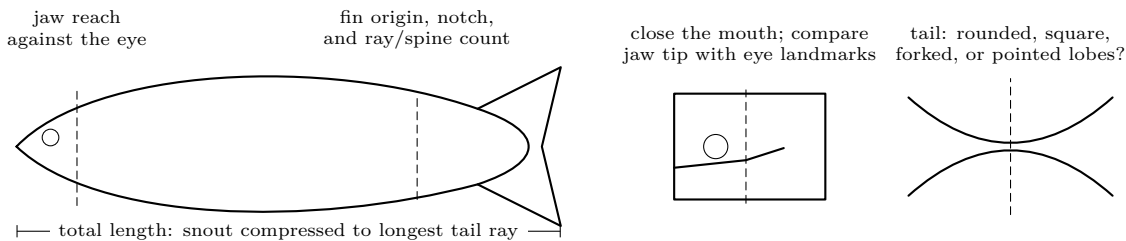
Fish, crayfish, and large invertebrates; shallow around warming cover, deeper or shaded in heat.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



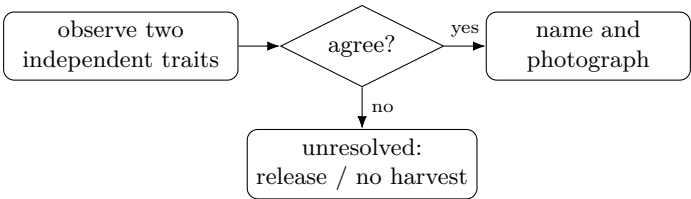
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Close the mouth and compare the jaw tip with the rear edge of the eye.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Confirm a deep notch between the spiny and soft dorsal sections.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use the horizontal side band only after jaw reach and dorsal notch agree.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Largemouth Bass
Nearest alternative	Smallmouth jaw ends near mid-eye and usually shows vertical bars.
Required gate	Name largemouth only when the closed jaw reaches beyond the eye and the dorsal notch is deep.
Independent check	A true lateral photograph must show both closed jaw alignment and the dorsal connection.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected vegetation and shade, then the deep edge in clear midday conditions.
North	Test weed flats, wood, narrows, and current-adjacent ambush edges.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Log cover type and strike location; repeated fish from shade or vegetation test the habitat claim.

Presentations

1. **Weightless plastic.** Skip or pitch to holes and shade; let it fall on slack line and watch for movement.
2. **Texas rig.** Probe dense cover with enough weight for bottom contact, not more.
3. **Stop rule.** After several accurate casts without evidence, change cover type or depth before changing lure details.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Land promptly, wet hands, support larger fish horizontally, and never hang a heavy fish by the jaw.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	If harvested, favor a legal mid-size fish over a scarce trophy; larger adults are valuable spawners.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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